

A course in language creation



Conlangs University

Lexicon 2

Metaphor



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Conceptual Metaphor

A **metaphor** is a figure of speech that refers to one thing as being another thing. We often use them to highlight some quality shared between two things, for example I might say "My friend Carl is a real tiger." Obviously Carl is not *literally* a tiger. But I'm saying he is one, maybe to emphasize he's ferocious or wild or somehow tiger-y in some way. You usually would make this kind of metaphor impromptu, and it depends mostly on some shared idea of what tigers are like, that you expect whoever you're talking to to understand. They also depend on some context--your conversation partner has to know who Carl is and why it would be relevant for you to say he's a tiger.

There's another sort of metaphor, that's sort of built into a particular language. A **conceptual metaphor** refers to the process of understanding or discussing one domain of ideas by mapping it to another. The real ideas you're talking about are called the **target domain** and the group of ideas you're using metaphorically to talk about them are called the **source domain**. Speakers of a language will know some conventionalized mappings in their language, and they can use these mappings to build new metaphors that others will understand. These mappings can differ across languages and cultures. They're a good way to create a lot of internally consistent metaphors that can give a bit of flavor to your language, so when you're building a conlang, they can be a cool thing to think about.

Let's start with an easy one. Almost all (if not all) languages have some sort of metaphor mapping space to time. After all, it's pretty easy to conceptualize space, but can be hard to conceptualize time. Conceptual metaphors generally get written out in all caps, so we'd say **SPACE IS TIME**. We talk about durations as being "long" or "short," the same words we use for distance. An event might take place "far in the future" or have happened in the "distant past." Even though differences in time and differences in location don't inherently have to correspond, we tend to use the same lexicon to discuss them, because there's an overarching conceptual metaphor linking them.

Time isn't just about duration though. It flows. So it's not too surprising that we also equate movement in space with the passage of time. In English, at least, we say the future is in front of us and the past is behind us. So to be fancy we could call the metaphors **THE FUTURE IS IN FRONT** or **THE PAST IS BEHIND**. Again, if you think about how we talk about time in English, you'll find it's rife with metaphors, sometimes ones that are so conventionalized, we hardly even think of them as metaphors. You look *back* on something you did yesterday, but you look *forward* to something you're doing tomorrow. You can have a bright future *ahead* of you or put a dark past *behind* yourself. If you reminisce, you're thinking *back* on it. You get the point. The general metaphor is that just as we walk forwards along our path, we move forwards through time.

But this sort of thing isn't universal! Other languages can use different sorts of conceptual metaphors, mapping the same source domain to different target domains or vice versa. In Quechua, the past is in front of you, and the future is behind you. This seems backwards if you're an English speaker, but it has some logic to it (as all natural languages do!) You know what happened in the past but not the future, just as you can see the space in front of you but not the space behind you. In Chinese, the past is over you and the future is under you. "Next time" is literally "the time below" and "last week" is literally "the week above." This also has some logic: things fall. There's a natural tendency for things to progress down as time goes

on. Natural languages have all sorts of different ways of setting up these metaphors, and all of them produce valid, consistent, and interesting sets of expressions.

Conceptual metaphors can sometimes reflect the attitudes of the speakers towards a particular topic. If speakers of a certain language have a particularly confrontational way of talking, they might use a metaphor like **CONVERSATION IS A BATTLE**. If you convince the person you're having a discussion with, maybe you "defeat your adversary." Interrupting someone could be "invading," and rhetoric might be thought of in terms of "strategic and tactical maneuvers." Maybe on the other hand, your speakers collaborate and consider things a bit more, and say that **CONVERSATION IS COOKING**. If you make a point, you're "adding an ingredient to the pot," and pausing to consider something might be "letting it simmer." A controversial topic might "spice things up"...an idiom you're already familiar with. In English, many people use the metaphor that **CONVERSATION IS A JOURNEY**. You "follow the path" of someone's reasoning until you "arrive at" a mutual understanding. A distracted person takes a lot of "detours" while speaking, and if you don't understand them, you can "get lost." One of my favorites that I've seen in a conlang is the metaphor in Pecan's Otsegon language that **CONVERSATION IS A HACKY SACK**, where people take turns speaking by juggling and passing the conversation back and forth.

Sometimes metaphors are so ingrained in a language that speakers don't realize they're metaphors. In English, we mostly describe sound volume using specific lexical items, "loud" and "quiet," but we use a metaphor of height to describe pitch, saying a sound is "high" or "low." As an English speaker, I think of the pitch meanings of "high" and "low" as extensions of their height meanings, but there's nothing other than a metaphor tying them together. Even among languages that are closely related to English, the metaphors used to describe sound quality vary widely. Afrikaans uses the metaphor of **VOLUME IS HARDNESS**, and calls a loud noise **hard** and a quiet noise **sag**, direct cognates with English "hard" and "soft." In Danish, **en høj lyd** lit. "a high sound" is loud, whereas a high-pitched sound is said to be **lys** "bright". Metaphorical descriptors don't always have to come in perfect antithetical pairs. In French, loud noises are "strong" and quiet noises are "sweet/gentle," while high-pitched noises are "sharp" and low-pitched noises are "heavy/solemn." You can get some mismatch like this in English too, where the opposite of "loud" can be either "quiet" or metaphorical "soft," and the opposite of "high" as in pitch, can be either "low" or "deep."

Making your own metaphors

Just for fun, let's walk through the process of creating a conceptual metaphor. First you can start out by thinking of a source domain to pair with a target domain. You generally want these to both be pretty broad and to have some kind of intuitive relationship between them. Something like **DOGS ARE WATER BOTTLES** doesn't make a good conceptual metaphor because it's too specific and there's no natural link between them. Something like **EMOTIONS ARE WEATHER** is better because both domains are broad, so you can get lots of mappings between them, but also because it's a very natural connection to make. Both emotions and weather change in quality and intensity in a pretty similar way, so it makes a lot of sense to map the domains to each other.

As I'm writing this, I've got **a certain song** stuck in my head...so how about we use an example like **LIFE IS A HIGHWAY**?

Okay, so if the target domain is "life" and the source domain is "a highway," what are some potential mappings? Think of things in the target domain that have a similar relationship to "life" as something in the source domain has to "a highway." People could be cars or individual drivers, since just like a person

moves through life, a car or driver moves through the highway. A person follows a certain path in life or with their career, just as a driver follows their lane on a highway. You get on the highway when you're born and you exit when you die. You can make a little table to show the mappings.

Target Domain: LIFE	Source Domain: A HIGHWAY
Person	Car/Driver
Career path	Lane
Death	Exit/off-ramp
Birth	On-ramp
Goals in life	Destination
Family and friends	A caravan
Achieving success	Driving in the fast lane
Enjoying yourself	Taking the scenic route
Having a hard time	Hitting traffic
A disaster	A car crash

Now that we have all these relationships, we can start making some idioms out of them. If someone meets an untimely demise, they "got off a few exits early." If somebody changes careers they can "change lanes" or "merge," and if it was really unexpected, maybe it was "without signaling." Someone who's going through life without much effort, might be "coasting" (hey, we say that in English!) Rockstars might write a song about living [life in the fast lane](#)...oh wait...no comment on the playlist that was on shuffle while I was writing this...anyway..

Conceptual metaphors show up all the time in language, and there are dozens of mappings we use in English that we're not even aware of. The next time you're chatting or reading something, pay attention to some of the metaphors you're using to express yourself and understand others. Metaphors can vary pretty freely. All you need is some sort of vague similarity in some quality or dimension of the source and target domains, and you can take it from there. After all, **METAPHORS ARE WATER** . They make things flow freely, we use them every day (even if we don't realize it), and after a long day, they sure are refreshing.